My Darling Sara

By Shane Koyczan

INTRODUCTION

Men grieve differently than women. Our cultural roles make it difficult for men to look for support, and harder again to accept it. Men are so often silent, solitary mourners who immerse themselves in activity and private, symbolic rituals. They feel profoundly, but often can't express the depth of their loss. Coping with the death of a loved one is never easy, regardless of how old you are when that loss occurs. However, turning a tragedy into a tribute is one of the ways that the survivors can keep going and keep living after a traumatic loss . . . A tribute to My Darling Sara by Shane Koyczan.

The failing use of my right hand

isn't actually the failing use of my right hand

It's just another way to tell the time

and I'm ticking

so I've been picking myself up at bars

with a bottle in each hand

but I never give myself any play

I only make plans with myself for the day after next

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but by the time the sun swings back around into position

I forget the context of why I asked myself out

in the first place

did I think I was going to score?

I let a stranger pour me one more

she says

my name is sara

doesn't take much more than that

to start a relationship

my darling sara

cleans rooms for a living

giving her youth and beauty

the dirt and dust

understands more than most

that family must be a foot you put forward first

you must weather the worst together

but having never met her family

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she places love above all else

then protests that I use the word love
too freely in poems
and I should really just say what I mean

and I suppose what I mean most is that
I'm trying

she's been buying me time
on a maxed out credit card
arms scarred from selling her own blood
to pay down the debt
tells me she doesn't mind going broke
just so long as I can give her a little sweat
she says
try

so I do my best impression
of a pen
and when every problem looks like a page

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I commit ink to paper
the worth of the words that come out
determines my wage
I've been making enough
to pay her the compliment
of not quitting
of not sitting
when standing is required
she only asks that I put the effort in
and in return she's willing
to pin a paper heart to her chest
then do her best impression
of a target

Sara tells me that effort
is the Siamese twin of success
so when everyone else looks like a wrong answer
she says she'll settle for being my best guess

so we lie in bed like a mess
that someone's been meaning to clean

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for the large part
of a long while
we lie there like a pile of dirty laundry
and how we'll ever come clean
is beyond me
so we don't

she says
it's supposed to be dirty
if by the end you haven't hurt me
then you didn't try

so I do my best impression
of a surgeon
cutting purple hearts out of my own
use my veins like thread
then have hurt sewn to our skin like medals
because when the bleeding stops
and the dust settles
all we have are our wounds
to wear like decorations

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upon our chest

Sara does her best impression of a war
tells me not to count my pride among the casualties
because maybe faith means never keeping score
she says there's more to effort than just switching gears
and in terms of what one should give in this life
sweat holds more value than tears

you have to try
and even though
the failing use of my right hand
means I'll never land a knockout punch
in the first round
life is composed of sound and fury
whatever noise is left in me
will be twice as loud when I try
so I plug myself into the idea of going the distance
and I amplify

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Sara has a throat like a vase
she sings her words into bloom
has a voice like perfume
It's been sticking to my clothes
so everyone knows where I've been sleeping

She's been keeping me so close
you could use my body for evidence
pull her fingerprints as proof
that she's been on top so often
she's beginning to look like my roof

but a real sexy roof
and she doesn't leak

unless you count the crying

she does that sometimes
worries that she's just a back up plan
but I've lived long enough to learn
too many options can kill a man

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I will make no exodus
I'll be around long enough
to watch uncertainty bid us farewell
then echo our names into the crater
caused by the impact
of when our lack of conviction fell

Sara,
you've never had to sell me on the idea
of absolute certainty in the trustworthiness of another
the first and only time you met my mother
mom said
"I like the way she looks at you"
and I echoed back to her
that I liked it too

eyes like recycle bin blue
she looks at broken things
as if she can make them new
more than a few times I've caught her staring
caught her wearing

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a smile reserved for those busy making plans

Sara believes that distance is a fundamental
that can be side-stepped by a piece of string
and two tin cans

and I remember when my tin can rang
they said
there's no family to speak of
so love is next in line
and there's not a lot of time
she's asking for her boyfriend

in the cab to the hospital I feel my heart bend
as if bracing for impact
so I do my best impression of a man
and face the fact

it's supposed to hurt

a doctor does his best impression of the truth

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and spares me his attempts to skirt around the issue

they can't stop the bleeding

and the failing use of Sara's heart
isn't actually
the failing use of Sara's heart
It's just another way to tell the time
and she's ticking

my darling Sara
I was holding your hand when you died
and even though the failing use of my right hand
prevented me from feeling you leave

I tried.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

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